

Pre-Market Checklist

The exact routine professional traders follow before the market opens every single day.

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What you do before the market opens determines the quality of your trading day. A structured pre-market routine eliminates reactive decision-making, keeps you focused on your best setups, and ensures you are never caught unprepared by what the market does at 9:30 AM. This routine takes 90 minutes. It is worth every minute.

6:00 – 7:00 AM

Overnight Review

Check overnight futures — ES (S&P 500) and NQ (Nasdaq 100). Are they up or down? By how much? Look at any major gap up or gap down relative to yesterday's close. Read news headlines for anything that moved markets overnight: earnings releases, Federal Reserve statements, economic data, geopolitical events. Note the pre-market high and low on your key watchlist names from yesterday.

7:00 – 8:00 AM

News and Catalysts

Check your news sources for stocks with significant pre-market volume. Look specifically for earnings beats or misses, FDA decisions, major analyst upgrades or downgrades, large contract announcements, and any sector-moving news. These are your potential gap plays and news-driven trades. Volume without news is suspicious. Volume with a clear catalyst is opportunity.

8:00 – 9:00 AM

Build Your Watchlist

Narrow your pre-market scans down to 3 to 5 names maximum. More than 5 and you are not watching — you are reacting. For each name, define before the open: the key technical level, your specific entry trigger, your stop loss level, and your price target. If you cannot define all four, that stock does not belong on your watchlist.

9:00 – 9:30 AM

Final Preparation

Check the VIX — elevated VIX means more volatile opens, require more patience. Check SPY and QQQ pre-market levels relative to key daily chart levels. Set price alerts on every watchlist name. Review your game plan one final time. Do not adjust your plan after the open unless the thesis changes entirely. Reactive adjustments at the open are almost always wrong.

PRE-MARKET CHECKLIST — PRINT AND USE DAILY

Fill this out every morning. If you cannot answer a question, do more research before the open.

Date and day of week

ES futures: direction and % change from yesterday's close

NQ futures: direction and % change from yesterday's close

Key economic data releasing today and expected time

VIX level — and how does this affect my aggression today?

SPY pre-market level — above or below key daily level?

QQQ pre-market level — above or below key daily level?

Sector or theme driving the market today (tech, energy, rates, etc.)

WATCHLIST — TOP 3 TO 5 NAMES ONLY

TICKER	CATALYST	KEY LEVEL	ENTRY TRIGGER	STOP	TARGET	MAX SHARES

Today's game plan — what is my focus? What conditions would make me more aggressive? What would make me step back?

What will I NOT do today? (name a specific bad habit to avoid)

TST RULE

Most retail traders open their platform at 9:29 AM with no plan, no watchlist, and no defined risk. They react to whatever moves first. You will not be one of them. The traders who do the work before the open consistently outperform the ones who show up unprepared. Preparation is your edge.

Full pre-market preparation methodology covered in the TST Academy Intermediate section at topstocktrading.com